



Grounding Cards

12 practical prompts for returning attention to the present moment

Choose one small sensory or body-based prompt when thoughts or feelings feel overwhelming.

Grounding Cards

Teens and adults

Use one card at a time

Pick the card that feels easiest. Try it for 30 to 90 seconds, then decide whether to repeat it, choose another, or reach out for support. There is no right way to feel afterward; the goal is simply to notice the present moment.

How to use this tool

Work through the pages in any order. Use a pen, pencil, or digital annotation tool. Keep what helps; leave what does not.

Important

If a prompt increases distress, stop and choose a different support. This tool is not a substitute for professional or emergency care.

Cut-apart grounding cards

Five Details

Name five things you can see. Describe one detail about each.

Cut along the border | Keep this card where it is useful

Four Contact Points

Notice four places your body meets the chair, floor, clothing, or wall.

Cut along the border | Keep this card where it is useful

Sound Map

Name three close sounds, two distant sounds, and one sound you choose to follow.

Cut along the border | Keep this card where it is useful

Color Hunt

Choose one color. Find five objects containing it.

Cut along the border | Keep this card where it is useful

Texture Pause

Safely touch three textures. Name each: smooth, rough, soft, firm, or mixed.

Cut along the border | Keep this card where it is useful

Orienting Sentence

Say: I am in _____. It is _____. The next safe thing I can do is _____.

Cut along the border | Keep this card where it is useful

Cut-apart grounding cards (continued)

Supportive Object

Hold or look at an everyday object. List three simple facts about it.

Cut along the border | Keep this card where it is useful

Feet and Floor

Press both feet gently into the floor, release, and repeat five times.

Cut along the border | Keep this card where it is useful

Slow Count

Count backward from 20 while looking at one object or number at a time.

Cut along the border | Keep this card where it is useful

Present-Moment Sketch

Draw three shapes you can see. It does not need to look like art.

Cut along the border | Keep this card where it is useful

Temperature Check

Notice whether your hands, face, and feet feel warm, cool, or neutral.

Cut along the border | Keep this card where it is useful

Choice Card

Choose one: sip water, change posture, open a window, step outside, or contact support.

Cut along the border | Keep this card where it is useful

What worked for me?

Card I tried

What was happening before I used it?

Intensity before (0-10)

Intensity after (0-10)

Would I try this again? Why or why not?

Make your own grounding card

Write a short, safe prompt you would genuinely use. Keep it concrete and kind.

My card title

My one-step prompt

A supportive phrase I can add

When I might use it

Sources and use note

This printable tool was designed with general self-care and coping concepts from the sources below. It is educational material, not health care or therapy.

National Institute of Mental Health: Caring for Your Mental Health

Self-care, connection, stress-management framing

<https://www.nimh.nih.gov/health/topics/caring-for-your-mental-health>

National Institute of Mental Health: So Stressed Out

Journaling, relaxation, mindfulness, sleep, and support concepts

<https://www.nimh.nih.gov/health/publications/so-stressed-out-fact-sheet>

NHS: Breathing exercises for stress

Comfortable, unforced breathing guidance

<https://www.nhs.uk/mental-health/self-help/guides-tools-and-activities/breathing-exercises-for-stress/>

WebMD: What Is Box Breathing?

Optional paced-breathing presentation

<https://www.webmd.com/balance/what-is-box-breathing>

WebMD: Quick Stress-Relief Rituals

Sensory grounding context

<https://www.webmd.com/depression/quick-stress-relief-rituals>

American Psychological Association: Stress management tips

Thought, emotion, behavior, and reframing context

<https://www.apa.org/topics/stress/tips>

CASEL: Fundamentals of SEL

Emotion identification and self-management framing

<https://casel.org/fundamentals-of-sel/>

CDC: Information for Family Caregivers

Caregiver capacity, breaks, and support framing

<https://www.cdc.gov/disability-and-health/about/information-for-family-caregivers.html>

Child Mind Institute: How to Help Children Calm Down

Coping-ahead and child-friendly calming support

<https://childmind.org/article/how-to-help-children-calm-down/>

Wikipedia: Mindfulness

Plain-language background only; not clinical authority

<https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Mindfulness>

Reddit community discussions

User-centered presentation inspiration only; not clinical authority

https://www.reddit.com/r/Anxiety/comments/1ch67c8/making_an_anxiety_tool_box_what_should_i_put_in_it/

YouTube guided box-breathing example

Visual pacing inspiration only; not clinical authority

<https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=tEmt1Znux58>